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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1949, 1956-1957

Coverage Date: 1850-1956

Place Coverage

eastern Southern province, Zambia; northern Matabeland North and Mashonaland West provinces, Zimbabwe

Section Title(S)

Summary of Cultural Variations within the Valley

Upper River region is more densely populated than Middle River region. Land pressure is also greater. Inheritance claims to fields are more firmly upheld; quarrels over land and over domestic boundaries between fields are more frequent and more violent. Perhaps in response to the pressure upon land, labour migration also seems to be of greater importance than in Middle River where men go out largely to meet contingent expenses as to find cash for bridewealth, fines and taxes, and in hunger years to reduce the drain on stores of food. Upper River men go for longer periods and in recent years many have taken their wives with them. Moreover, since about 1952 women and children have joined the stream of migrants for work, many of them going to the Plateau for some months each year to work on tobacco farms in Kalomo District.

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Variations in social organization are more deep-rooted. Both regions have exogamous clans, but the clan names are not identical, nor where the same clan names occur are they necessarily coupled with the same animal associates. Names which in one region are alternative names for the same clan refer to distinct clans in the other region. Thus Bakuli, Batenda and Baunga are alternative names for one Middle River clan. Each is a separate Upper River clan. Middle River clans are linked together as clan joking-partners in a manner comparable to that found among the Plateau Tonga,

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though the clan joking relationship is of less functional significance in the Valley.¹ Upper River clans do not have joking partners. Instead there appears the *silufulo* arrangement whereby lineages of the same clan are linked together to perform funeral rituals and for other purposes. Middle River people do not have the *silufulo* relationship and lineages of the same clan are related to one another only by their common clanship.

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Clans

The systems of classifying kinsmen differ in the two regions. In Middle River region, all members of one's father's lineage are usually equated as one, the only distinction made being that of sex. All male members of that lineage are termed 'father' and reply with the term 'child'. All female members are termed '23 grandmother' and reply with the term 'grandchild'. In the Upper River region, members of one's father's lineage are classified by generation as well as by sex, just as is done within one's own lineage. Terminology and treatment of affines also varies regionally. A Middle River man is on a joking basis with the wives of both his sister's sons and his mother's brothers. An Upper River man must treat these women with the greatest circumspection.

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¹ See Colson, 1953 *b*, for the Plateau Tonga clan joking relationship.

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